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Review Article

The Theory of the Public Sphere

John B. Thompson

The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere: An Inquiry into a Category of Bourgeois Society

by Jürgen Habermas

Translated by Thomas Burger with the assistance of Frederick Lawrence

Cambridge, MA: MIT Press; Cambridge, UK: Polity Press, 1989, pp. 301 + xix, £29.50 hbk, £11.95 pbk.

Habermas and the Public Sphere

edited by Craig Calhoun

Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1992, pp. 498 + x, £40.50 hbk.

We have waited nearly three decades for the publication in English of one of Habermas's most stimulating works: his path-breaking study of the emergence and transformation of the bourgeois public sphere in Europe, from the early modern period to the present day. Originally written as Habermas's *Habilitationsschrift* and first published in 1962, this book sparked off a lively debate in Germany and was subjected to extensive critical discussion (see Hohendahl, 1979). In the English-speaking world, by contrast, the issues raised by *The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere* have, until recently, been largely neglected. Most of the standard English-language commentaries on Habermas devote relatively little attention to this early work, and there is a dearth of good critical literature. Anyone wishing to recommend relevant texts to students, until recently, would have been hard pressed to come up with something resembling a reading list.

We owe a large debt to Craig Calhoun for putting together what

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will surely become a central text for the critical appreciation of Habermas's work on the public sphere. *Habermas and the Public Sphere* originated in a conference that was held in September 1989 to mark the publication in English of *Structural Transformation*; the volume consists of fifteen essays, together with a lengthy introduction by Calhoun and a substantial reply by Habermas. Like many edited volumes, *Habermas and the Public Sphere* is probably too long, and it contains too much repetition to be read comfortably from cover to cover. (The repetition is, to some extent, an outcome of the decision to retain something of the conference format: every two essays are followed by a third which comments on them.) But these considerations do not diminish the value of the book. *Habermas and the Public Sphere* is a rich and wide-ranging interrogation of some of the key ideas that have shaped Habermas's theoretical approach from the outset. It demonstrates clearly that, despite the thirty years that have lapsed since the original publication of *Structural Transformation*, this work has lost none of its capacity to stimulate critical reflection and productive research in the social sciences and humanities.

Readers who have followed the development of Habermas's work will know that his views have changed in certain respects since the early 1960s. He has become increasingly concerned with the problem of clarifying the normative foundations of critical theory, and at the same time he has tried to work out a new and distinctive account of the social organization and developmental trajectory of modern societies. These twin concerns are reflected in his writings of the 1980s and early 1990s — in *The Theory of Communicative Action* (1981) above all, but also in a series of other publications. Many readers may wonder whether, in pursuing this intellectual course, Habermas has abandoned altogether the themes that preoccupied him thirty years ago. They will therefore be particularly interested to read Habermas's contribution to the volume edited by Calhoun. Here Habermas returns to the central themes of *Structural Transformation*, reassessing their significance in the light of recent research and with the benefit of the kind of distance produced by the passage of time. As we have come to expect of him, Habermas engages with his critics in a generous and even-handed way, often conceding that their criticisms are justified and that the arguments of *Structural Transformation* could no longer be sustained today without substantial modification.

In this review article I shall not try to address all of the issues

raised by *Structural Transformation* or by the many interesting contributions in the volume edited by Calhoun. I shall, instead, focus on a selection of issues that seem to me to have the greatest relevance to current debates in social and political theory. I shall begin by outlining briefly Habermas's original account of the emergence and transformation of the bourgeois public sphere. I shall then consider some of the most important criticisms that can be found in the literature, and shall consider Habermas's response to them. In the final section I shall raise a few issues which have not received much attention in the literature to date, but which, in my view, would have to be taken into account by any attempt to rethink the theory of the public sphere in the late twentieth century.

I

Structural Transformation is an extended reflection on the nature of public life and on the ways in which it has changed in the course of the historical development of the West. Like other social and political thinkers, Habermas traces the distinction between 'public' and 'private' back to classical Greece. In the city-states of ancient Greece, the sphere of the *polis* was separated from the private realm of the *oikos*. Public life was constituted in the market place and in the assemblies where citizens came together to discuss the issues of the day; the public sphere was, in principle, an open field of debate in which those individuals who were entitled to the status of citizens could interact with one another as equals. While this classical conception of public life has had an enduring influence on Western thought, the institutional forms of publicness have varied greatly from one historical period to another. In the European Middle Ages, argues Habermas, a distinct public sphere did not exist; at this time, publicness was more like a status attribute of kings and lords. Public figures displayed themselves as representatives or embodiments of a higher power. This 'representative publicness', as Habermas calls it, achieved its most elaborate expression in the courtly life of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries, after which it gradually declined in significance.

The development of mercantile capitalism in the sixteenth century, together with the changing institutional forms of political power, created the conditions for the emergence of a new kind of public sphere in early modern Europe. In this context, the meaning of 'public authority' began to shift: it began to refer less to the

domain of courtly life and increasingly to the activities of an emerging state system which had legally defined spheres of jurisdiction and a monopoly on the legitimate use of violence. At the same time, 'civil society' emerged as a domain of privatized economic relations which were established under the aegis of public authority. The 'private' realm thus comprised both the expanding domain of economic relations and the intimate sphere of personal relations which became increasingly disengaged from economic activity and anchored in the institution of the conjugal family. Between the realm of public authority or the state, on the one hand, and the private realm of civil society and the family, on the other, there emerged a new sphere of 'the public': a bourgeois public sphere which consisted of private individuals who came together to debate among themselves concerning the regulation of civil society and the conduct of the state. This new public sphere was not part of the state but was, on the contrary, a sphere in which the activities of the state could be confronted and subjected to criticism. The medium of this confrontation was itself significant: it was the public use of reason, as articulated by private individuals engaged in argument that was *in principle* open and unconstrained.

The emergence of the bourgeois public sphere was facilitated by two other developments which play a key role in Habermas's account. One development was the rise of the periodical press. Habermas attributes particular importance to the kind of critical journals and moral weeklies which began to appear in some parts of Europe in the late seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. While these publications often originated as journals devoted to literary and cultural criticism, they increasingly became concerned with issues of more general social and political significance. The second development was the rise of a variety of new centres of sociability in the towns and cities of early modern Europe. These included the salons and coffee houses which, from around the mid-seventeenth century on, became places of discussion and milieux in which educated elites could interact with one another and with the nobility on a more-or-less equal footing.

It was in England at the beginning of the eighteenth century that the most favourable conditions were created for the emergence of the bourgeois public sphere. Censorship and the political control of the press were less stringent in England than in some other parts of Europe. The system of licensing, which had been re-established by Charles II in 1662, fell into abeyance at the end of the seventeenth

century and was followed by a spate of new periodical publications. At the same time, coffee houses proliferated; by the first decade of the eighteenth century, there were an estimated 3000 coffee houses in London alone, each with a core of regular clients. Many of the new periodicals — like the *Tatler*, the *Spectator*, Defoe's *Review* and Swift's *Examiner* — were closely interwoven with the life of the coffee houses. These periodicals included essays of political commentary and satire which became an integral part of the discussions that took place in coffee houses and elsewhere. The periodical press thus became a key element of an emerging public sphere in which private individuals gathered together, in coffee houses and other centres of sociability, to engage in critical discussion about the activities of Parliament and Crown.

Part of Habermas's argument is that the critical discussion stimulated by the periodical press gradually had a transformative impact on the institutional form of modern states. By being constantly called before the forum of the public, Parliament became increasingly open to scrutiny, eventually abandoning its right to prevent the publication of its proceedings. Moreover, with the development of modern constitutional states in which certain basic rights and freedoms — including the freedom of speech and expression — are guaranteed, the political role of the public sphere was formally recognized in law. These developments were, Habermas argues, of considerable significance; they are an enduring testimony to the political impact of the bourgeois public sphere and to the role it played in the shaping of Western states. But Habermas also wants to show that, in the specific form in which it existed in the eighteenth century, the bourgeois public sphere did not last for long.

The decline of the bourgeois public sphere was the result of several overlapping trends. The separation between the state and civil society — which had created an institutional space for the public sphere — began to break down, as states assumed an increasingly interventionist character and took on more and more responsibility for managing the welfare of citizens, and as organized interest groups became increasingly assertive in the political process. At the same time, the institutions which once provided a forum for the bourgeois public sphere either died out or underwent radical change. The salons and coffee houses declined in significance, and the periodical press became part of a range of media institutions which were increasingly organized as large-scale commercial concerns. The commercialization of the media altered their character in

a fundamental way: what was once an exemplary forum of rational-critical debate became just another domain of cultural consumption, and the bourgeois public sphere collapsed into a sham world of image creation and opinion management in which the diffusion of media products is in the service of vested interests.

With the demise of the bourgeois public sphere, public life in modern societies has, Habermas suggests, taken on a quasi-feudal character. Sophisticated new media techniques are employed to endow public authority with the kind of aura and prestige which was once bestowed on royal figures by the staged publicity of feudal courts. This 'refeudalization of the public sphere' turns politics into a managed show in which leaders and parties seek, from time to time, the acclamatory assent of a depoliticized population. The mass of the population is excluded from public discussion and decision-making processes and is treated as a managed resource from which political leaders can elicit, with the aid of media techniques, sufficient assent to legitimate their political programmes. In developing this rather pessimistic argument, Habermas was no doubt overstating his case (we shall return to this point below); but he should also be given credit for anticipating, with remarkable prescience, the glittering media campaigns that were to become such a pervasive feature of presidential and general elections in the age of television.

Although developments in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries have radically transformed the nature of public life, Habermas wants to argue that the bourgeois public sphere embodied certain ideas and principles which retain their relevance today. The most important idea in this regard is what Habermas sometimes refers to as the 'critical principle of publicity', as distinct from 'publicity' understood in the more modern sense of product promotion or advertising. The critical principle of publicity is an idea which Habermas traces back to Kant's writings on enlightenment: it is the idea that the personal opinions of private individuals could evolve into a public opinion through a process of rational-critical debate which was open to all and free from domination. Habermas wishes to maintain that, despite the decline of the bourgeois public sphere which provided a partial and imperfect realization of this idea, the critical principle of publicity retains its value as a normative ideal, a kind of critical yardstick by means of which the shortcomings of existing institutions can be assessed. The critical principle of publicity is the core concept of a theory of democracy and of

democratic will-formation which, at the time of writing *Structural Transformation*, Habermas was only just beginning to formulate.

The normative issues that Habermas was addressing in *Structural Transformation* have, of course, continued to preoccupy him in recent years, although the way in which he addresses these issues has changed in certain fundamental respects. Habermas became increasingly convinced that his earlier approach — in which normative issues were addressed largely through an immanent critique of an historically emerging set of ideas — was unsatisfactory. It did not provide a sufficiently compelling account of why the principles once expressed in the bourgeois public sphere should continue to have any hold on us today. Habermas therefore moved away from the kind of normative argument sketched in *Structural Transformation* and tried to show — eventually by means of his theory of communicative action and his notion of discourse ethics — that the normative problems confronting a critical theory of society could be handled in terms of a conception of rationality which has a certain binding and unavoidable character. We shall return to these issues later. But first I want to consider some of the other problems raised by Habermas's account.

II

Structural Transformation offers an historical narrative of the changing forms of public life which is, in many ways, quite compelling. It combines a perceptive historical account of the political culture of early modern Europe with a sharp critical perspective on the degradation of public life in our societies today. But how good are Habermas's arguments, both in historical terms and at a more general theoretical level? If we re-examine these arguments today, with the benefit of hindsight and in the light of work that has been done over the last few decades, how well do the arguments hold up?

Undoubtedly part of the rhetorical force of *Structural Transformation* stems from the way that Habermas weaves together historical analysis and normative critique — a feature that has bothered some commentators over the years. I shall not object in principle to this aspect of Habermas's work, but I will try to distinguish the substantive issues from the normative ones and to deal with each separately. In this section I shall focus on four problems (or sets of problems). All of these are now reasonably well discussed in the critical literature — both in *Habermas and the*

Public Sphere and elsewhere — and I shall be drawing on this literature here.

(1) Let us begin by considering, from an historical point of view, the adequacy and plausibility of Habermas's account of the emergence of the bourgeois public sphere in early modern Europe. One of the criticisms that has been made most frequently of this account is that, by focusing attention on the *bourgeois* public sphere, Habermas tends to neglect the significance of other forms of public discourse and activity which existed in seventeenth, eighteenth and nineteenth-century Europe, forms which were not part of, and in some cases were excluded from or opposed to, the forms of bourgeois sociability. This point is made very effectively by Geoff Eley in the Calhoun collection, though somewhat similar criticisms can be found in earlier German literature.¹ As Eley remarks, the work of E.P. Thompson, Christopher Hill and others has highlighted the significance of a variety of popular social and political movements in the early modern period, and it cannot be assumed that these movements were either derivative of, or organized along similar lines to, the activities which took place in the bourgeois public sphere. On the contrary, argues Eley, the relation between the bourgeois public sphere and popular social movements was often a conflictual one. Just as the emerging bourgeois public sphere defined itself in opposition to the traditional authority of royal power, so too it was confronted by the rise of popular movements which it sought to contain. The bourgeois public sphere was, from the outset, embedded in a field of conflictual social relations which shaped its formation and development.

This is a forceful line of criticism. In the Preface to *Structural Transformation*, Habermas had explained that his account would be limited to, as he put it, 'the liberal model of the bourgeois public sphere', and that he would leave aside that 'variant' of the liberal model — what he called 'the plebeian public sphere' — which had briefly appeared on the stage of the French Revolution but which was subsequently suppressed in the historical process. But it seems clear that this schematic way of characterizing popular social and political movements was not satisfactory. Returning to these issues thirty years later, Habermas concedes that his earlier account would have to be substantially revised today. Not only were popular movements much more important in the early modern period than he had previously allowed, but it is also clear that they cannot be adequately understood as mere variants of the liberal model of the

bourgeois public sphere (any more than popular culture can be understood as a derivative of dominant cultural forms). Habermas acknowledges that we need a more flexible approach to popular social movements and popular cultural forms, an approach which does not prejudge their character and which allows for the possibility that they may have a shape and dynamic of their own.

(2) Let us now focus on the model of the bourgeois public sphere itself, quite apart from the question of whether this model provided a satisfactory way of thinking about the character of non-bourgeois social movements. It is clear that this model was regarded by Habermas as an idealization of actual historical processes. Although the bourgeois public sphere was based on the principle of universal access, in practice it was restricted to those individuals who had the education and the financial means to participate in it. What does not emerge very clearly from Habermas's account, however, is the extent to which the bourgeois public sphere was not only restricted to educated and propertied elites, but was also a predominantly *male* preserve. Habermas was not unaware of the marginalization of women in the bourgeois public sphere and of the patriarchal character of the bourgeois family; but it could be argued very plausibly that, at the time of writing *Structural Transformation*, he did not appreciate the full significance of this issue.

In recent years a number of feminist scholars have examined the gendered character of the public sphere and political discourse in the early modern period, and have brought sharply into focus a set of issues which remained rather blurred in Habermas's account. Particularly interesting in this regard is Joan Landes's (1988) *Women and the Public Sphere in the Age of the French Revolution*.² Landes is concerned with the relation of women to the public sphere in France in the period from 1750 to 1850. Her central argument is that the exclusion of women from the public sphere was not simply a contingent historical circumstance, one of the many respects in which the public sphere in practice fell short of the ideal; rather, the exclusion of women was constitutive of the very notion of the public sphere. For the notion of the public sphere, as it was articulated in the political discourse of the time, was juxtaposed to the private sphere in a gender-specific way. The public sphere was generally understood as a domain of reason and universality in which men were uniquely well equipped to participate, while women, being inclined (supposedly) to particularity and to mannered, frivolous talk, were commonly thought to be better suited to domestic life.

Hence the masculine character of the bourgeois public sphere was not an incidental aspect: it was a fundamental feature of a public sphere which, in its very conception, was shaped by a deeply rooted set of assumptions about gender differences.

It is to Habermas's credit that, in reconsidering these issues today, he is swayed by the force of this line of argument. He accepts that, while workers and peasants as well as women were largely excluded from the bourgeois public sphere, the exclusion of women needs to be thought about differently, precisely because this exclusion had, as Habermas now puts it, 'structuring significance'. This shift in Habermas's approach is important, but one might reasonably remain a little sceptical about the extent to which Habermas has taken account of gender issues. For, as Nancy Fraser (1989) has shown, a somewhat similar line of argument can be developed with regard to Habermas's more recent work. It may be that, while Habermas is certainly sympathetic to the issues raised by feminist critics, these issues remain somewhat tangential to the basic assumptions and priorities that shape his way of conceptualizing the social world.

(3) The weakest parts of *Structural Transformation* are probably not the sections concerned with the emergence of the bourgeois public sphere, but rather the sections concerned with its alleged decline. Surprisingly, Habermas's arguments concerning the transformation of the public sphere in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries are not addressed in any detail by the contributors to *Habermas and the Public Sphere*, though they are reconsidered by Habermas himself in his reply. If one re-reads today Habermas's account of the changes which have occurred over the last two centuries, one will find many details to dispute and some empirical material which is now well out of date. But the important question is whether Habermas was right to interpret these changes broadly in the way that he did — as a sign that the public sphere of debating citizens had collapsed into a fragmented world of consumers who are enthralled by the media spectacles unfolding before them and manipulated by media techniques. Is there any substance to this interpretation and, more specifically, to the thesis of the refeudalization of the public sphere?

I doubt it. Certainly this account has some *prima facie* plausibility. One need only watch a few party political broadcasts to remind oneself of the extent to which the conduct of politics today has become inseparable from the activity of public relations

management. But if we press beyond the level of initial observations, it is clear that there are serious deficiencies to Habermas's account. Let me highlight two. In the first place, it is very doubtful whether the recipients of media products can plausibly be regarded as enthralled and manipulated consumers. In developing this argument, Habermas was betraying his debt to the work of Horkheimer and Adorno, whose theory of mass culture provided part of the inspiration for his own account. Today it is clear, however, that this kind of argument exaggerates the passivity of individuals and takes far too much for granted concerning the process of reception; a more contextualized and hermeneutically sensitive approach would show that the process of reception is a much more complicated and creative activity than the Frankfurt School theorists supposed (this point has been developed in more detail in Thompson, 1990: Ch. 2). Habermas now accepts the force of this criticism and acknowledges that, if he were to rework his account of the transformation of the public sphere, he would have to give more attention to recent work on the reception of media products.

A second problem in Habermas's account concerns the thesis of the refeudalization of the public sphere. It is not difficult to see why Habermas had argued that the public sphere was being 'refeudalized': the showiness characteristic of mediated politics today, and its concern to cultivate personal aura rather than to stimulate critical debate, does seem, at least at first glance, to resemble the kind of representative publicness typical of the Middle Ages. But the similarity here is more apparent than real, and the fact that Habermas could seriously make this comparison suggests that he had not really appreciated the quite profound impact that the mass media have had on the modern world. For the development of the media — and especially of the various types of electronic communication — has created new forms of social interaction and information diffusion which exist on a scale and are organized in a manner that preclude any serious comparison with the theatrical practices of feudal courts. Whereas courtly behaviour in the Middle Ages was largely oriented towards individuals who shared the same spatial-temporal context, today it is common for political leaders to appear before millions of recipients who are widely dispersed in space (and perhaps also in time); and the kinds of relationship established through mediated communication are quite different from the face-to-face interaction which takes place in a shared locale. I shall return to these issues below. Here it will suffice to say

that, if we wish to understand how public life in the modern world has been reshaped by the development of the media (among other things), we would be well advised to put aside the thesis of the refeudalization of the public sphere and to think about these issues in a different way.

(4) I mentioned earlier that *Structural Transformation* could be viewed as an initial attempt to outline a theory of democracy that would be relevant to the conditions of twentieth-century Western societies. Although the bourgeois public sphere has long since declined, the critical principle of publicity retains some relevance as a normative ideal and could be used to guide institutional change. In the closing pages of *Structural Transformation*, Habermas put forward a few ideas about how the critical principle of publicity could be implemented within the organizations and interest groups which had assumed an ever-increasing role in political affairs. In sketching these proposals for a kind of 'intra-organizational democratization', Habermas was indebted to the work — little known in the English-speaking world — of Wolfgang Abendroth. (Habermas's *Habilitationsschrift*, having apparently been received unfavourably by Horkheimer and Adorno, was submitted to Abendroth at Marburg, and the book was subsequently dedicated to him.) But the proposals put forward by Habermas were, at best, exceedingly vague; and Habermas himself gradually came to the view that, given the complexity of modern, internally differentiated societies, such proposals would be largely unworkable in practice.

In recent decades Habermas has continued to pursue the question of how a theory of democracy, informed by the ideas once embodied in the bourgeois public sphere, could be developed and applied to the conditions of modern societies. This has involved two parallel lines of argument. In the first place, Habermas has tried to show that the notion of a discursive formation of the will through a process of reasoned debate can be given a firmer foundation than it had in *Structural Transformation*, and that this notion forms the core of a discourse-centred theory of democracy in which questions of a moral-practical character can be resolved in a rational manner (see Habermas, 1990, 1992). Certainly this line of argument has not won universal assent. Even Habermas's most sympathetic critics find much with which to disagree in his account of practical discourse (see the fine essays by McCarthy, Benhabib and Fraser in *Habermas and the Public Sphere*); and many have doubted whether, in view of the plurality of evaluative and interpretative standpoints

characteristic of modern societies, it makes sense to try to build a political theory based on the possibility of rational consensus. Habermas's arguments concerning the theory of practical discourse and its political application have given us a great deal to think about and will, no doubt, continue to generate much debate. But it seems to me that, at least in some respects, his critics are justified, and it would probably be sensible for Habermas to tone down some of his stronger claims in favour of a more modest approach.

The second line of argument developed by Habermas has involved a substantial revision of his theory of society, culminating in the distinction between system and lifeworld elaborated in *The Theory of Communicative Action* (Habermas, 1987). This distinction has major implications for Habermas's theory of democracy. He now accepts that the state and economy are systematically organized fields of action which can no longer be transformed democratically from within: to attempt to do so would be to threaten their capacity to function according to their distinctive logic, with potentially disastrous consequences. The task today of a radical programme of democratization should be, instead, to push back the colonizing intrusion of system imperatives into the lifeworld and to achieve thereby a new balance between forms of societal integration, so that the practically oriented demands of the lifeworld can prevail over the exercise of economic and administrative power.

Not everyone will be convinced that, with the notions of system and lifeworld, Habermas has found the most compelling way to reformulate the political programme of radical democratization. Some will doubt whether the state and economy should be insulated from democratic processes in the manner proposed, and many will wonder what all of this amounts to in practice. Moreover, in developing his theory of society in recent years, Habermas seems largely to have lost sight of a theme that concerned him in his earlier work — namely, the importance of communication media and their structuring impact on social and political life. I want to conclude by returning briefly to this theme and asking whether it can be reformulated in a way that does justice to the forms of mediated communication which are increasingly common in the world today.

III

In the previous section I have considered some of the criticisms that have been made of Habermas's early writings on the public sphere

and some of the reasons why Habermas subsequently modified his views. However, there is one issue which has not figured prominently in the debate sparked off by Habermas's work, and yet which is, in my view, of considerable significance for any attempt to rethink the changing character of public life. The issue, put simply, is this: Habermas's conception of the public sphere — whether in the form of the bourgeois public sphere which emerged in the eighteenth century, or in the form of his own, philosophically more elaborate model of practical discourse — is essentially a *dialogical* conception. That is, it is based on the idea that individuals come together in a shared locale and engage in dialogue with one another, as equal participants in a face-to-face conversation. The problem, however, is that this conception bears little resemblance to the kinds of communication established by and sustained through the media, and hence bears little resemblance to the kind of public sphere which the media have helped to create.³ Let us consider this problem further by returning for a moment to the arguments of *Structural Transformation*.

Many commentators have noted that, in accounting for the formation of the bourgeois public sphere, Habermas attributes a significant role to print. But if we re-read *Structural Transformation* carefully, we will find, I think, that Habermas was not interested in print as such, in the distinctive characteristics of this communication medium and in the kinds of social relations established by it. His way of thinking about print was shaped by a model of communication based on the spoken word: the periodical press was part of a conversation begun and continued in the shared locales of bourgeois sociability. The press was interwoven so closely with the life of clubs and coffee houses that it was inseparable from it: 'One and the same discussion transposed into a different medium was continued in order to re-enter, via reading, the original conversational medium' (*Structural Transformation*, p. 42). So while the press played a crucial role in the formation of the bourgeois public sphere, the latter was conceptualized by Habermas not in relation to print, but in relation to the face-to-face conversations stimulated by it. In this respect, Habermas's account of the bourgeois public sphere bears the imprint of the classical Greek conception of public life: the salons, clubs and coffee houses of Paris and London were the equivalent, in the context of early modern Europe, of the assemblies and market places of ancient Greece. As in ancient Greece, so too in early modern Europe, the public sphere was

constituted above all in speech, in the weighing up of different arguments, opinions and points of view in the dialogical exchange of spoken words in a shared locale.

It is not difficult to see why, with this conception of the public sphere in mind, Habermas was inclined to interpret the impact of newer communication media, like radio and television, in largely negative terms. It was not only because the media industries had become more commercialized and harnessed to particular interests; it was also because the kind of communication situation they created, in which the reception of media products had become a form of privatized appropriation, was a far cry from the dialogical exchange that took place among individuals who gathered together in the clubs and coffee houses of early modern Europe (see *Structural Transformation*, pp. 163–5). Habermas recognizes, of course, that radio and television create new forms of conversation — the TV chat shows, panel discussions, and so on. But these new forms of conversation, he argues, are in no way comparable to the critical-rational debate that was constitutive of the bourgeois public sphere. ‘Today the conversation itself is administered’ (*Structural Transformation*, p. 164), and active debate among informed citizens has been replaced by the privatized appropriation of a conversation carried out in their name.

However, we shall not arrive at a satisfactory understanding of the nature of public life in the modern world if we remain wedded to a conception of publicness which is essentially dialogical in character, and which obliges us to interpret the ever-growing role of mediated communication as an historical fall from grace. We should, instead, recognize from the outset that the development of communication media — beginning with print, but including the more recent forms of electronic communication — has created a new kind of publicness which cannot be accommodated within the traditional model. With the development of communication media, the phenomenon of publicness has become detached from the sharing of a common locale. It has become *de-spatialized* and *non-dialogical*, and it is increasingly linked to the distinctive kind of visibility produced by, and achievable through, the media (especially television).

This is not the place to examine in detail the characteristics of this new form of mediated publicness and to assess its social and political implications.⁴ Such an enquiry would require us to attend much more carefully than Habermas has done to the nature of

communication media and their development over time; it would require us to look systematically at the social organization of the media industries on a global scale, and at the complex processes involved in the reception of media products; and, in general, it would require us to think again about what 'publicness' means in a world permeated by new forms of communication, a world in which information and symbolic content circulate through global networks at high speeds and in which individuals are able to interact with others, and observe persons and events, without ever encountering them in the same spatial-temporal locale. It is unlikely that this enquiry, in its more constructive dimension, would be greatly aided by Habermas's work — either his early work, which remained too closely tied to the traditional notion of publicness, or his more recent writings, which have, for the most part, become preoccupied with other themes. But there can be no doubt that, when Habermas outlined the arguments of *Structural Transformation* some thirty years ago, he set the terms of a debate which retains its urgency today and which deserves to be taken up, renewed and, indeed, resituated at the centre of social and political theory.

Notes

1. Earlier versions of this kind of criticism can be found in Negt and Kluge (1972) and Lottes (1979). Eley (in *Habermas and the Public Sphere*) draws on Lottes's work and discusses it in some detail.

2. See also Carole Pateman (1988), Mary P. Ryan (1990) and Catherine Hall (1992). Issues of gender are addressed by several of the authors in *Habermas and the Public Sphere*; see especially the contributions by Seyla Benhabib, Nancy Fraser, Keith Baker, Mary Ryan and Geoff Eley.

3. For a more detailed discussion of this issue, see Thompson (1990: 119–20 and 238–48); see also Thompson (forthcoming). The question of whether Habermas's conception of the public sphere is suitable for analysing mediated communication is raised by one or two contributions to *Habermas and the Public Sphere* (see especially the essay by Nicholas Garnham), but it is not taken up by Habermas.

4. This theme is pursued in my forthcoming book on social theory and the media.

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